

A question found in your own official table

Everything on these two pages was found this morning, from published sources, in under an hour — including the part we got wrong.

Step 1 — the first look

and why it was nearly worthless

Brunei's Labour Force Survey shows that in 2025 the sex balance of the unemployed flipped: **women rose from 46.8% to 51.7% of all unemployed people**. That looked like a finding.

It is not. Women are only **39.6%** of the labour force. A share of a count says as much about who is *in* the labour force as about who is out of work. **Never report a share when the denominators differ.** Compute the rate.

Step 2 — the rates, and the correction

DEPS, 18+

Unemployment rate (18+)	2024	2025	change
Men	4.16%	3.99%	-0.17
Women	5.44%	6.54%	+1.10
Gap (F – M)	+1.29 pts	+2.54 pts	widened
Participation rate, women	57.8%	57.1%	-0.7
Participation rate, men	75.9%	74.6%	-1.3

And the history removes the word "reversal" altogether. Women's unemployment rate has been **higher in every published year: 7.6% vs 6.1% in 2014, 9.8% vs 7.9% in 2017**.

The finding changed under checking. Not "the balance reversed in 2025" — but **a gap that has always been there widened by 1.25 points in one year**, while the count-share flip was mostly an arithmetic effect of a shrinking female labour force. Same table, one hour apart.

Computed from DEPS counts; every rate above was recalculated from the published numbers and checked to reconcile (labour force = employed + unemployed, exactly, both years, both sexes).

Step 3 — what actually moved

2024 → 2025

	Men	Women
Working-age population	+4,000	-1,300
Labour force	+700	-1,900
Employment	+900	-2,800
Unemployment	-200	+900

Of the 2,800 women who left employment, 900 kept looking and 1,900 left the labour force entirely. Those 1,900 are counted nowhere in the unemployment rate. Nationally, employment fell 0.9% in a year when the working-age population grew 0.8%.

DEPS, Preliminary Report of the Labour Force Survey 2025 — deps.mofe.gov.bn/labour-force/



Three rivals, and the column none of them has

The same drill you ran yesterday on a fictional file — run here on your own country's numbers.

Step 4 — three explanations that exclude each other

H1 — Composition

Women's job losses are concentrated in one contracting sector, and the aggregate is really a sector story wearing a gender label. *Refuted if* the sectoral breakdown shows the losses spread evenly across sectors.

H2 — Withdrawal under worsening prospects

Prospects deteriorated and 1,900 women stopped searching rather than search in vain; the fall in the female working-age population is separate (ageing or migration). *Refuted if* the **potential labour force** — people who want work but are not searching — did not rise for women.

H3 — Queueing on a reservation wage

Better-educated women hold out for public-sector posts whose intake has shrunk, and stay unemployed rather than accept private work near the median wage. *Refuted if* unemployment duration for tertiary-educated women did not lengthen, or if their private-sector entry rose.

Each names a **different policy**. H1 → a sector intervention. H2 → care, transport and re-entry support. H3 → the wage and security gap itself. Getting this wrong is not an academic error; it is money spent on the wrong lever.

Step 5 — what the published data can already tell you

- **Women are better educated and more often unemployed.** In 2017, more tertiary-educated women were employed than men (**22,967 vs 21,016**) — from a much smaller female labour force — and more tertiary-educated women were unemployed (**2,162 vs 1,935**).
- **Unemployment here is a local phenomenon.** In 2020, **99.2%** of the unemployed were locals (16,858 of 16,989). Non-locals hold permits tied to jobs.
- **Underutilisation is far larger than unemployment.** 2017: labour underutilisation **47,812** against unemployment **19,053** — two and a half times.
- **Youth unemployment is the headline you actually mean.** Official 18–24 rates: **25.2% (2014), 26.3% (2017), 27.3% (2018)** — against a national rate of 5.0%. If you quote one without saying which, you have said something false.
- **Check the repeated claims.** "About 60% of employed nationals are in the public sector" does not survive the table: in 2020, **69,308 of 155,480 employed locals — 44.6%**.

DEPS Labour Market Indicators (18+, by sex) and LFS tables, deps.mofe.gov.bn

Step 6 — the column none of it has

No table above can see **whose household can afford the wait**; whether a woman's withdrawal was a decision or a constraint (childcare, elder care, no car); the **intake calendar** she was timing against; or what her family expected of her.

Yesterday, one of you wrote that your own design could never see "**tacit household financial agreements that enable long-term queuing for public-sector jobs**". A fictional interview written for the exercise said it more plainly: "**I was not unemployed exactly. I was waiting.**" **The national table and your own account agree** — and neither has a column for it.

Before anyone takes this further — three cautions

1. LFS 2025 is a **Preliminary Report**. Figures may be revised.
2. Estimates are rounded to the nearest 100. A subgroup change of a few hundred may sit inside sampling error. **We have not checked the coefficients of variation. That is step one.**
3. One year is not a trend — but the *gap* is multi-year and the *widening* is not. Say which of the two you are claiming.

